

Researcher Identity Memo

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Positionality

On the topic of positionality, I have some thoughts that seem to matter to the study. One, I am a counselor educator who supervises emerging counselors in a graduate counseling program. Two, I hope to become a supervisor for associate counselors soon. Three, my supervisor for licensure was a person of deep and overt faith. I have fond memories and a positive experience from this time. Four, as a counselor educator, I would like to serve on my state licensure board at some point.

Interests

The topic of supervision and faith is important to me for several reasons. First, I was supervised by a man who was overtly Christian in his interactions with me and in how he conceptualized clients. He was constantly using Scripture as a metaphor and as a guide to understanding human nature and psychopathology. Having had this experience, I reflect on the nurture I felt from his desire to draw near to God with me. I was often soothed from the stress of counseling by our conversations centered on Christ. I also reflect on the color his relationship with God offered on his insight into my countertransference and my clients' existential dilemmas. I have a wondering (one of his phrases) about how others might experience supervisors with a strong God attachment or with a faith that is in Fowler's Conjunctive stage of faith (1981).

Second, as a person who would like to include my own faith in supervisory relationships. I am curious about when people find it helpful, encouraging, or additive, or when they find it unhelpful. I am wrestling with the qualitative language for this. It may be more about the themes that I will discover in this research. If the themes are centered around a similar experience to mine, then I could generalize the quality of faith as a valid offering. If the themes centered on less positive experiences, I could generalize the quality of faith as interfering with supervisory duties. The real truth is, I will not know until I ask, and I have a wondering.

Thirdly, I sense there are more supervisors out there like the one that I had. I want to encourage these supervisors that their use of faith integration is a positive experience, and they should offer it more often without feeling ashamed.

Fourthly, as a counselor educator, I am curious about how to communicate a person's experience with a supervisor who uses faith integration. I can use my own experience, but communicating this phenomenon through data will be more accurate and exciting for students.

Assumptions

I have mentioned a few assumptions, but for the sake of clarity, let me make them overt. One assumption is that only Christians will desire faith integration in supervision or a supervisor who is strong in their faith. Another similar assumption is that non-Christian supervisees will not want or appreciate this integration.

Biases

Relational epistemology is gaining ground in my heart. As such, it will be difficult to hear and read about people who have had a different experience than I have in supervision, but it is necessary to fully accept their subjective truth. My bias may cause me to defend against any view that does not see a supervisor with a strong attachment to God or a well-developed faith as positive.

References

Fowler, J. W. (1981). *Stages of faith: The psychology of human development and the quest for meaning*. Harper & Row